

REVISED Formal Submission in Fiction**Evan Becza****Word Count: 2019****The Tryout**

The ceiling was the first thing he saw every morning. The cracked popcorn texture that covered the ceiling. Jack's eyes followed the same path they did every morning, but today, something was different. His chest was so tight he could barely breathe. He took a deep breath in, held it, and then let ~~is~~ **it** all out slowly. It was tryout day.

Downstairs, the house was dead silent. His dad was already gone, another double shift at work. The silence was so loud. On the counter, right next to the half-empty glass of milk, was a folded paper napkin. Jack didn't even have to open it to know what it said. He could sense his dad's handwriting from a mile away. It read, "Good luck." He carefully folded it and slipped it into his pocket. Jack didn't really believe in luck, but the weight of the napkin was real. He could imagine his dad's voice.

The field had seen better days, the grass was long and patchy, and it was positioned on **a** slightly slanted hill. The late autumn air attacked Jack's ears and fingers. Other guys were already on the pitch, shooting balls at the empty net, laughing, shoving each other in a playful way. Acting like it was just another Tuesday. Jack took a seat on the bleachers, retying his cleats. The laces were either too tight, or too loose, he couldn't get the right feel. For him, this wasn't just practice. This was everything. His last chance. No more bus rides with the team to away games, no more varsity jacket, nothing.

Coach Puma's whistle screeched, a sound that felt like it was scratching the inside of Jack's brain. "Bring it in, let's go! On the line!" Puma's voice was the same awful tone from

freshman year, the year he'd cut Jack after the first day. He'd made JV as a sophomore, rode the bench as a junior, and now, as a senior, this was it. Varsity or nothing.

The warm-up laps in the cold air were a foreshadowing of what was to come. The dribbling drills were worse. The ball felt foreign, his touch was completely off and not under control. "Jack! You look like you're running in quicksand! Loosen up!" Puma barked from the center circle, not even looking at him. Jack forced a nod, despised.

Then came the scrimmage. The moment of truth. Obviously, he was on the second squad, the team the coach didn't really pay attention to. His stomach rumbled. He saw Liam, the starting center-mid, smiling with no worries in the world as he stretched his hamstring.

The head ref, Jack's history teacher, blew the whistle to start the game. The game was a mess, disoriented and cold. The varsity guys moved like a pack of wolves, their passes crisp, and runs smooth. His squad was a bunch of individuals just chasing the ball. For ten minutes, he was a ghost. A jersey just moving through space, barely touching the ball, his lungs burning just trying to keep up. No one even looked at him. Then, a chance. A loose pass rolled his way. Jack controlled in clean, glanced up, and sent a crisp cross-field pass that found another teammate running. A small spark of confidence grew inside him. But the momentum didn't last too long. Moments later, Jack tried to take a touch past a defender and tripped over the ball, falling awkwardly in front of him. The defender easily stole it, and Jack scrambled to his feet, sighing to himself.

Then it happened. Liam, trying to show off, tried to do a fancy flick that went wrong. The ball came loose from a tangled mess of legs, and suddenly, it was right there, rolling to his feet like it was on a platter.

The shouts of “Man on!”, the clacking of boots, Puma’s yelled instructions, just vanished. It was just him and twenty yards of open grass. His legs had a mind of their own. He was going fast, really fast, the turf under his cleats in a familiar way. The thumping of his own heart and himself breathing were the only sounds in the world. This was the moment he’d replayed in his head a thousand times before.

“Go, Jack! Take him!” someone from his team screamed.

He saw the keeper, a big kid named Mark. He charged out of the net. Jack’s mind went blank, his body taking over. He faked right, a drop of the shoulder, then dragged the ball back left with his foot. It was pure muscle memory, a move he’d practiced over and over. The move worked. Mark was fooled, stumbling to the right. The net was wide open. He pulled his leg back, planted his foot, and struck the ball clean with his laces.

PING.

The sound was like a bell, high pitched, a note that seemed to linger in the air. The ball smacked the far post, vibrating on impact, before bouncing back into the field directly into the path of a recovering varsity defender who cleared it up the field. All the parents and kids sighed on the sideline.

“Let’s go! Play on! It’s still live!” Puma yelled, his whistle screaming again. Jack kept running, his body on autopilot, but something inside him was off. His chest felt hollow for the rest of the scrimmage. Every touch after was heavy, sparking a memory of that miss. He was invisible again.

When it was finally over, his lungs were on fire, and his legs were cooked like spaghetti. He put his hands on his head and breathed heavily. Puma called them into a huddle near the bench. A couple of guys were already talking about whose house they were going to for pizza.

No one looked at him. No one mentioned the post. The moment had already been forgotten, but not for Jack.

“Alright, listen up,” Puma said, clipboard held tight against his chest. “Rosters posted on the locker room door tomorrow at seven a.m. Sharp.” He looked at all the tired faces. “Good work out there today. Some of you surprised me.” Jack’s brain was stuck on that last part, repeating it in his head. Did I surprise him? By hitting the post? But the hope didn’t feel real, like a thin sheet of ice over a lake.

That night, his dad got home late. The sound of the key in the lock and the sigh as he dropped his bag by the door were the only noises in the house. Jack was still at the kitchen table in his sweaty hoodie, the ping of that goalpost replaying in his ears.

“You did your best, son?” his dad asked. The question was almost a ritual.

“I guess,” Jack mumbled.

“You don’t sound sure.”

Jack just shrugged. “Doesn’t matter. Coach already knows who he wants. He knew from the first day of tryouts.”

His dad sat down across from him, the chair creaking. The kitchen was dim. You could see the rings around his dad’s eyes. “You think I got this job, got us here, because things were fair?” Jack stayed quiet. “I came to this country with two hundred dollars,” his father said, “I wanted you to have chances I didn’t. You have to take advantage of your opportunities. You understand?” Jack nodded, not because he suddenly believed, but because it was easier than arguing.

The next morning, he was at school by 6:45 a.m. The hallway leading to the locker room was empty, and the lights were bright. A small crowd had already gathered by the time he got

there. He stood on his toes, his heart beating fast, scanning the list taped to the green door. He read it once. Then again, slower, tracing each name. His name wasn't there. He felt calm, like the silence before screaming. The world stopped. Then, without a word, he turned and started walking back down the hall.

"Hey, Jack!"

It was Owen, the varsity captain. He jogged up, his face looked sympathetic. "Rough man. You played hard. That shot, you almost had it."

"Yeah," Jack said, "Almost." He tried to smile, but it felt fake.

On his way home, he cut through the park, past the empty varsity field. He stopped, right by the goalpost, the same one he had hit yesterday. He reached out and felt the cold, painted medal.

For the next three days, he was a ghost at school. He avoided the cafeteria where the team would be; and instead took the long way to his classes. He told his dad he was staying late for study sessions, but instead, he went to the public fields a mile from his house to practice on until nine. The ones nobody else used. He would take a bag of old balls and just shoot. Again, and again and again. Left foot, right foot. Volleys, chips, shots. He wasn't playing for a coach, or a roster spot, or anyone's approval anymore. He was playing because the feel of the ball on his feet was the only thing that made him feel fine. It was his therapy.

One evening, as he was packing his water bottle and the scattered balls into his bag, a shadow appeared over him.

"Still here?"

Jack turned. It was Coach Puma, standing there in his casual clothes. He looked different.

"Yeah," Jack said, "Just shooting around."

The coach nodded. “That shot you took on Tuesday that hit the post. You got the keeper completely. The touch, the feint. You almost had it.”

“Almost doesn’t count,” Jack said.

Puma smiled a little. “You know, I used to think that too. I rode the bench for two years at a D-III school. But sometimes, the ones who almost make it end up being the ones who teach the game. They end up coaching.”

Jack became confused. “Are you saying I should quit playing and become a coach?”

“No,” Puma said. “I’m saying the game is bigger than high school. You’ve got heart, Jack. Not just skill, but heart. And that’s the rarest thing. Most guys, when they get cut, they hang up their cleats. They don’t spend their nights at a public field trying to get it right.” They stood there for a moment, the only sound being the low hum of the field lights above them.

Finally, Puma broke the silence. “My cousin runs a U19 community team. They practice at Docherty Park. But they need a center midfielder. Theirs just broke his collarbone. They’ve got a game on Sunday.” He mentioned. “I can give him your number if you want. No promises though.” Jack hesitated. A part of him wanted to say no. To stay angry and tell Puma to get lost. But the other part spoke first.

“Yeah,” he said, his voice quiet. “Okay.”

The first practice with Steel United was messy. The field at Docherty Park was terrible. The jerseys were a faded maroon, and they smelled faintly of mildew. Half the players argued about every call, and the coach, a loud, bearded man named Stew, spent most of his time trying to get them to stop yelling at each other. But when Jack first touched the ball, weaving through two defenders, something inside him, finally changed. There was no pressure here. No judgment. By the end of the scrimmage, he was drenched in sweat, his knees were covered in mud, and he

was laughing with the kids. It wasn't varsity soccer. There were no college scouts, no quality turf. But the ball was the same. The goals were the same. And the joy of touching the ball was the same. It was still the same game.

That night, walking home under the streetlights, he passed the high school. He could see the varsity team practicing under the stadium lights, running the same drills, hearing the same screech of Puma's whistle. He watched for just a moment, then turned and continued walking. In his pocket, the napkin his dad had written on was still folded. He didn't need to take it out. He knew the words by heart. Good Luck.

Best Writing Exercise from Creative Nonfiction Unit

Writing Exercise #2

We left the house early in the morning, heading to the marina, just before the sun began to rise. As always, we had to prepare before we headed out. My dad grabbed the boat lines, pulling it in closer so we could transfer items from the car. While he worked, I hopped on board, turned on the battery, flipped a couple switches, and listened to the hydraulics as I trimmed the engine down. Then, I inserted the key, started the engine, and listened to its hum as the water swirled behind it. It was a perfect early fall day for striper fishing.

While waiting for my dad to finish, I watched boats glide past the marina as the sun rose, their wakes entering the marina and nudging the boats around. The gentle sounds of the water were always calming. Other boaters began to arrive as well, which was a good sign. Soon, we untied the ropes and creaky pulleys and headed toward open water. The fifteen-minute ride through the canal was smooth, the boat slicing through the water as we made our way to the open ocean.

Two Original Poems

Poem 1 - Writing Exercise #15

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Poem 2 - Fishing with my cousin

The sun is high, the sky is blue,
We push the boat and hope for a few.

Lines in the water, quiet and still,
Waiting for fluke to bite at our skill.

Cousin's bait flies, lands with a splash,
A crab steals it in a daring dash.

The rod bends hard, we reel with a cheer,
A fluke jumps up, the moment is clear.

Water everywhere, laughter in the air,
Messy hands, tangled lines, without a care.